# Sha Elijah Biruar Dumama-Alba

**Atty. Sha Elijah Biruar Dumama-Alba** is a Maguindanaoan lawyer, legislator, and public servant widely regarded as one of the most consequential figures in the young history of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM).

A woman of firsts, she served as the inaugural Attorney General of the BARMM and later became the first woman to head the Ministry of the Interior and Local Government (MILG) in the region.

Her career is anchored on a principle she has championed publicly and personally: **Moral Governance**, the idea that public service must be grounded in integrity, transparency, and the lived values of the Bangsamoro people.

She completed both the regular Philippine Bar and the special Shari'ah Bar, placing third nationally in the 2018 Shari'ah Bar Examinations, a distinction that positions her as a rare legal voice capable of navigating both the secular and Islamic legal traditions of the Philippines.

As a member of the Bangsamoro Transition Authority (BTA) Parliament, she served as Floor Leader and Chairperson of the Committee on Rules, helping lay down the foundational laws that would define how the region governs itself for generations.

She belongs to the **Maguindanaoan** ethnic group, one of the principal Moro peoples of Mindanao.

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**Atty. Sha Elijah Biruar Dumama-Alba**




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| **Born** | Early 1980s, Cotabato City, Philippines |
| **Ethnicity** | Maguindanaoan |
| **Education** | University of the Philippines Diliman (B.S. Public Administration); San Beda University (Juris Doctor); Development Academy of the Philippines (M.P.M.) |
| **Bar Admissions** | Philippine Bar; Shari'ah Bar (3rd placer, 2018) |
| **Known For** | First Attorney General of BARMM; First Woman Minister, MILG-BARMM; Moral Governance advocacy |
| **Political Party** | Bangsamoro Transition Authority (BTA) Parliament |
| **Positions Held** | Bangsamoro Attorney General (2019–2023); Minister, Interior and Local Government (2023–present); Deputy Speaker, Bangsamoro Parliament (2025–present) |
| **Awards** | 2019 Obama Foundation Leader (Asia-Pacific); 2025 TOWNS Awardee |

# Early Life and Family Background

Sha Elijah Biruar Dumama-Alba was born in the early 1980s in Cotabato City, a city that sits at the political and cultural heart of the Bangsamoro region.

She grew up in a household shaped by public service. Both of her parents were doctors and government workers, and that dual commitment to professional excellence and community duty left a deep impression on her.

She was a remarkably fast learner from the start. She completed high school at just 14 years old, a fact that points to the kind of intellectual drive that would later define her career.

In her early college years, she followed her father's preference and enrolled in a pre-medical course. By her third year, however, she had made a decisive turn toward law, a shift that would eventually take her to the highest legal office in the Bangsamoro.

That pivot, from medicine to law, turned out to be one of the most consequential decisions in Bangsamoro legal history.

# Education

Atty. Dumama-Alba's educational path reflects both academic rigor and a deliberate orientation toward public life.

She earned her **Bachelor of Science in Public Administration** from the **University of the Philippines Diliman**, one of the country's most competitive and respected public universities.

She went on to complete her **Juris Doctor** at **San Beda University**, a law school with a strong national reputation for producing bar topnotchers and public interest lawyers.

She later added a **Master's Degree in Public Management**, with a specialization in Regional and Local Governance, from the **Development Academy of the Philippines**, deepening her understanding of how government actually works at the ground level.

Her most distinctive academic achievement came in 2018, when she placed **3rd in the Special Shari'ah Bar Examinations**, making her one of a very small number of lawyers in the Philippines admitted to both the regular Philippine Bar and the Shari'ah Bar.

That dual admission is not just a credential. It reflects a genuine commitment to serving a community whose legal needs span two distinct systems of law.

# Career

## Bangsamoro Attorney General (2019–2023)

When the BARMM was formally established in 2019 under the Bangsamoro Organic Law, it needed legal infrastructure as much as it needed political leadership.

Atty. Dumama-Alba stepped into that need as the **first-ever Attorney General of the BARMM**, serving as the chief legal advisor to the Chief Minister and the entire Cabinet.

The role placed her at the center of some of the most complex legal questions facing a newly autonomous region: How do you translate a peace agreement into workable governance structures? How do you build institutions that respect both national law and the unique legal traditions of the Bangsamoro?

She held the position from 2019 to 2023, a period that coincided with the critical early years of the region's transition.

### Legislative Leadership in the Bangsamoro Transition Authority

As a Member of Parliament in the BTA, Atty. Dumama-Alba took on a legislative leadership role that went well beyond representing a constituency.

She served as **Floor Leader** of the BTA Parliament and as **Chairperson of the Committee on Rules**, two positions that put her squarely in charge of how the parliament functioned as a body.

In that capacity, she helped shepherd the passage of two foundational laws: the **Bangsamoro Electoral Code** and the **Bangsamoro Local Governance Code**.

These aren't routine pieces of legislation. They are the legal backbone of how the region elects its leaders and how its local governments operate. Getting them right mattered enormously.

### Minister of the Interior and Local Government (2023–present)

In December 2023, Atty. Dumama-Alba was appointed **Minister of the Interior and Local Government (MILG)** of the BARMM, becoming the **first woman** to lead that ministry.

In this role, she oversees local government units across the Bangsamoro, leads disaster preparedness efforts through the BARMM-READi framework, and manages public safety functions across the region.

The ministry sits at the intersection of governance, security, and community service. It's not a comfortable desk job. It's a position that demands constant engagement with local leaders, first responders, and the communities they serve.

### Deputy Speaker, Bangsamoro Parliament (2025–present)

In November 2025, Atty. Dumama-Alba was sworn in as one of the **Deputy Speakers of the Bangsamoro Parliament**, adding another layer of legislative leadership to an already substantial career.

## Institutional Contributions

Beyond her formal positions, Atty. Dumama-Alba played a significant institutional role through her co-leadership of the Joint Secretariat of the **Intergovernmental Relations Body (IGRB)**, the key coordination mechanism between the national government in Manila and the Bangsamoro government in Cotabato City.

That kind of intergovernmental work is often invisible but always essential. It's the plumbing of federalism: making sure the different levels of government can actually talk to each other and resolve disputes without things breaking down.

Her consistent presence in that mechanism helped keep the Bangsamoro transition on track during some of its most delicate moments.

## Moral Governance Advocacy

Atty. Dumama-Alba has been one of the clearest and most consistent voices for **Moral Governance** in the Bangsamoro.

The principle, as she has articulated it, is about more than just avoiding corruption. It's about integrating the ethical and spiritual values of the Bangsamoro people, rooted in Islamic principles, into the everyday practice of public administration.

For a region that has spent decades negotiating its place within the Philippine state, this kind of value-driven governance is not abstract philosophy. It's a practical framework for building institutions that the Bangsamoro people can genuinely trust and own.

## Legacy and Cultural Significance

Atty. Dumama-Alba represents something genuinely new in Bangsamoro public life: a woman who has succeeded at the highest levels of both legal and political leadership, in a context where those doors were not always open.

Her success in passing both the Philippine Bar and the Shari'ah Bar, and her career that spans the Attorney General's office, the parliament, and a cabinet ministry, makes her one of the most versatile and accomplished public servants the Bangsamoro has produced.

She has advanced the cause of **women's empowerment** not through speeches alone but through the accumulation of firsts: first woman to hold this position, first woman to lead that ministry.

She has also helped legitimize and formalize the **Shari'ah justice system** within the Philippine legal framework, demonstrating through her own career that Islamic law and constitutional law can coexist and reinforce each other.

As a Maguindanaoan woman who has navigated both the national institutions in Manila and the regional institutions of the Bangsamoro, she functions as a living bridge between two worlds that sometimes struggle to understand each other.

## Recognition

**2025 TOWNS Award**
: Recognized by the TOWNS Foundation, Inc. for exceptional contributions to **Peacebuilding and Good Governance**.

**2019 Obama Foundation Leader (Asia-Pacific)**
: Selected as one of the Obama Foundation Leaders from the Asia-Pacific region, a program that identifies and supports emerging public leaders across the region.

**Asia Foundation Development Fellow**
: Recognized as a Development Fellow by the Asia Foundation, an international development organization focused on governance and civil society.

## See Also

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
- Bangsamoro Organic Law
- Bangsamoro Transition Authority (BTA)
- Shari'ah Bar Examinations (Philippines)
- Ministry of the Interior and Local Government, BARMM

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